Seminar 1:

Classroom problems and worked solutions

25117 - Econometrics

Universitat Pompeu Fabra

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The issue: what can data tell us about training?

- A university offers job training. We want to understand students' employment and earnings, and decide what the evidence says about the programme.
- We will describe uncertainty, study relationships, and compare ways to estimate an average.
- For every problem: identify the relevant population, write the calculation, and interpret the result in words and units.

Classroom problems

Each problem states its own population and assumptions. Work through the questions before drawing a policy conclusion. Worked solutions follow each problem.

Problem 1: Who receives weekly job earnings?

Select one of four students with equal probability. Weekly job earnings, measured in hundreds of euros, are

Student	s_1	s_2	s_3	s_4
$W(s)$	0	0	1	3

1. Construct the probability mass function of W. Check that its probabilities sum to one.
2. Write and sketch the complete c.d.f. $F_W(w) = \Pr(W \leq w)$.
3. Find $F_W(0)$, $F_W(1)$, $\Pr(0 < W \leq 1)$, and $\Pr(W \geq 1)$. Why do s_1 and s_2 correspond to one value of W?

Solution 1: The earnings probability distribution

1.

w	0	1	3
$\Pr(W = w)$	1/2	1/4	1/4

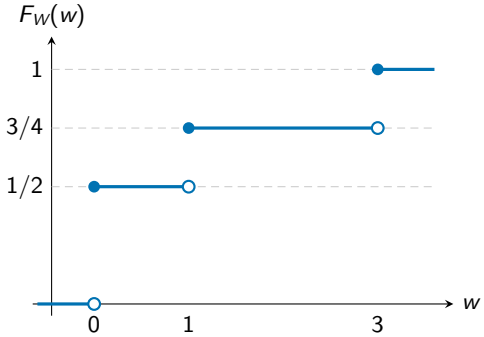
$$\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{4} = 1.$$

Solution 1: The earnings c.d.f. (continued)

2.

$$F_W(w) = \begin{cases} 0, & w < 0, \\ \frac{1}{2}, & 0 \le w < 1, \\ \frac{3}{4}, & 1 \le w < 3, \\ 1, & w \ge 3. \end{cases}$$

At each jump, the filled dot gives the value of the right-continuous c.d.f.



3.

$$F_W(0) = \frac{1}{2}, \qquad F_W(1) = \frac{3}{4},$$

$$\Pr(0 < W \le 1) = F_W(1) - F_W(0) = \frac{1}{4}, \qquad \Pr(W \ge 1) = 1 - \Pr(W = 0) = \frac{1}{2}.$$

Distinct students s_1 and s_2 both have $W = 0$.

Problem 2: How long until a training interview?

Waiting time T, measured in hours, is continuous with density

$$f_T(t) = \begin{cases} ct, & 0 \le t \le 1, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

1. Find c so that f_T is a valid density. Sketch the density.
2. Derive the complete c.d.f. $F_T(t)$, including values outside $[0, 1]$.
3. Calculate $\Pr(T \le 1/2)$ and $\Pr(1/4 < T \le 3/4)$. Shade the corresponding areas under the density.
4. Find $\Pr(T = 3/4)$. Does a density greater than one at $t = 3/4$ violate a probability rule?

Solution 2: A density and its cumulative probability

1.

$$1 = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f_T(t)\,dt = \int_0^1 ct\,dt = \left[\frac{ct^2}{2}\right]_0^1 = \frac{c}{2} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \boxed{c = 2}.$$

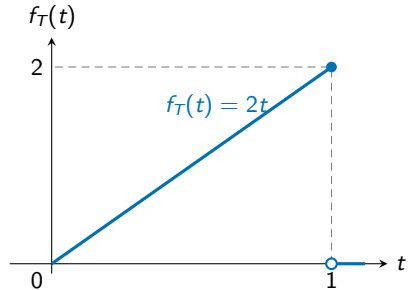
2. For $0 \le t \le 1$,

$$F_T(t) = \int_0^t 2u\,du = t^2.$$

Thus the complete c.d.f. is

$$F_T(t) = \begin{cases} 0, & t < 0, \\ t^2, & 0 \le t \le 1, \\ 1, & t > 1. \end{cases}$$

1. Density sketch

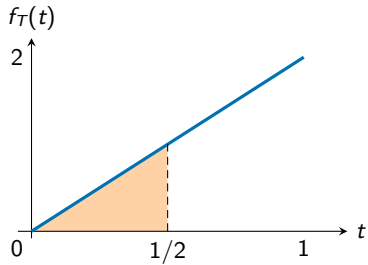


The density is nonnegative and its total area is one; its integral gives accumulated probability.

Solution 2: Probabilities are shaded areas (continued)

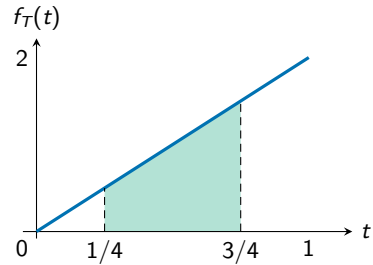
3.

Waiting at most half an hour



$$\Pr(T \le \frac{1}{2}) = \int_0^{1/2} 2t\,dt = \left[t^2\right]_0^{1/2} = \boxed{\frac{1}{4}}.$$

Waiting between 15 and 45 minutes



$$\Pr(\frac{1}{4} < T \le \frac{3}{4}) = \frac{9}{16} - \frac{1}{16} = \boxed{\frac{1}{2}}.$$

4. $\Pr(T = 3/4) = 0$: a single point has zero area. The height $f_T(3/4) = 3/2$ per hour is allowed; probabilities are integrals, not density heights.

Problem 3: What are typical weekly earnings?

Use the earnings distribution from Problem 1:

w (hundreds of euros)	0	1	3
$\Pr(W = w)$	1/2	1/4	1/4

1. Compute $\mu_W = \mathbb{E}(W)$ and $\mathbb{E}(W^2)$.
2. Calculate $\mathrm{Var}(W)$ from the weighted squared deviations. Check it using $\mathbb{E}(W^2) - [\mathbb{E}(W)]^2$.

Solution 3: Average earnings and variance

1.

$$\mathbb{E}(W) = \frac{1}{2}(0) + \frac{1}{4}(1) + \frac{1}{4}(3) = 1, \qquad \mathbb{E}(W^2) = \frac{1}{4}(1) + \frac{1}{4}(9) = \frac{5}{2}.$$

2.

Weighted squared deviations

$$\begin{aligned}\mathrm{Var}(W) &= \frac{1}{2}(0-1)^2 + \frac{1}{4}(1-1)^2 \\ &\quad + \frac{1}{4}(3-1)^2 \\ &= \frac{1}{2} + 0 + 1 = \boxed{\frac{3}{2}}.\end{aligned}$$

Second-moment shortcut

$$\begin{aligned}\mathrm{Var}(W) &= \mathbb{E}(W^2) - [\mathbb{E}(W)]^2 \\ &= \frac{5}{2} - 1^2 = \boxed{\frac{3}{2}}.\end{aligned}$$

Problem 4: Do participants find jobs more often?

For a randomly selected student, let $D = 1$ denote training participation and $H = 1$ employment. The table gives joint probabilities from an observational population.

	$D = 0$	$D = 1$	Total
$H = 0$	.30	.10	
$H = 1$	.30	.30	
Total			1

1. Complete the marginal totals. Find $\Pr(D = 1, H = 1)$.
2. Calculate $\Pr(H = 1 \mid D = 1)$, $\Pr(D = 1 \mid H = 1)$, and $\Pr(H = 1 \mid D = 0)$.
3. Find $\mathbb{E}(H \mid D = 1)$ and $\mathbb{E}(H \mid D = 0)$. Use iterated expectations to recover $\mathbb{E}(H)$.

Solution 4: Participation, employment, and conditioning

1.

	$D=0$	$D=1$	Total
$H=0$	.30	.10	.40
$H=1$	.30	.30	.60
Total	.60	.40	1

$$\Pr(D=1, H=1) = .30.$$

2.

$$\Pr(H=1 \mid D=1) = \frac{.30}{.40} = .75,$$

$$\Pr(D=1 \mid H=1) = \frac{.30}{.60} = .50,$$

$$\Pr(H=1 \mid D=0) = \frac{.30}{.60} = .50.$$

3. Because H is binary, $\mathbb{E}(H \mid D=d) = \Pr(H=1 \mid D=d)$. Therefore

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}(H) &= \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}(H \mid D)] \\ &= .75\Pr(D=1) + .50\Pr(D=0) = .75(.40) + .50(.60) = \boxed{.60}.\end{aligned}$$

Problem 5: What would independence look like?

Before training begins, an independent lottery assigns $A = 1$ with probability .40. Use the marginal distribution of H from Problem 4. Lottery assignment is independent of H.

1. Use independence to construct the full joint probability table of (A, H), including marginal totals.
2. Calculate $\Pr(H = 1 \mid A = 1)$, $\mathbb{E}(AH)$, and $\mathbb{E}(A)\mathbb{E}(H)$.

Solution 5: Independence before the programme

1.

	$A=0$	$A=1$	Total
$H=0$	.24	.16	.40
$H=1$	.36	.24	.60
Total	.60	.40	1

Every cell factorizes:

$$\Pr(A=0,H=0)=.60(.40)=.24,$$
$$\Pr(A=1,H=0)=.40(.40)=.16,$$
$$\Pr(A=0,H=1)=.60(.60)=.36,$$
$$\Pr(A=1,H=1)=.40(.60)=.24.$$

2.

$$\Pr(H=1\mid A=1)=\frac{.24}{.40}=.60=\Pr(H=1),\qquad \mathbb{E}(AH)=.24=.40(.60)=\mathbb{E}(A)\mathbb{E}(H).$$

Problem 6: How strongly do training and jobs move together?

Return to the observational population in Problem 4:

	$D = 0$	$D = 1$	Total
$H = 0$	.30	.10	
$H = 1$	.30	.30	
Total			1

1. Find $\mathbb{E}(D)$, $\mathbb{E}(H)$, $\mathrm{Var}(D)$, $\mathrm{Var}(H)$, and $\mathbb{E}(DH)$.
2. Calculate $\mathrm{Cov}(D, H) = \mathbb{E}(DH) - \mathbb{E}(D)\mathbb{E}(H)$. Interpret its sign.
3. Find $\mathrm{Corr}(D, H)$. Explain the role of standard deviations in this calculation.
4. Recode participation as $Q = 100D$. Find $\mathrm{Cov}(Q, H)$ and $\mathrm{Corr}(Q, H)$. What happens to correlation if employment is replaced with unemployment $U = 1 - H$?

Solution 6: Means, variances, and product moment

1. For any binary variable $B \in \{0, 1\}$ with $p_B = \Pr(B = 1)$,

$$\mathbb{E}(B) = \sum_{b=0}^{1} b \Pr(B = b) = p_B, \qquad \text{Var}(B) = \mathbb{E}(B^2) - [\mathbb{E}(B)]^2 = p_B - p_B^2 = p_B(1 - p_B),$$

using $B^2 = B$. From the joint distribution in Problem 4,

$$\mathbb{E}(D) = 0(.60) + 1(.40) = .40, \qquad \mathbb{E}(H) = 0(.40) + 1(.60) = .60,$$
$$\text{Var}(D) = .40(1 - .40) = .24, \qquad \text{Var}(H) = .60(1 - .60) = .24.$$

The product expectation is

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}(DH) &= \sum_{d=0}^{1} \sum_{h=0}^{1} dh \Pr(D = d, H = h) \\ &= 0(.30) + 0(.10) + 0(.30) + 1(.30) = .30.\end{aligned}$$

Only the $(D, H) = (1, 1)$ cell contributes, so $\mathbb{E}(DH) = \Pr(D = 1, H = 1)$.

Solution 6: Covariance from the lecture definition

2. *Lecture 1, "Covariance"* defines covariance using deviations from the means. Let $\mu_D = \mathbb{E}(D)$ and $\mu_H = \mathbb{E}(H)$. Expanding that definition gives

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{Cov}(D, H) &= \mathbb{E}[(D - \mu_D)(H - \mu_H)] \\
&= \mathbb{E}[DH - \mu_D H - \mu_H D + \mu_D \mu_H] \\
&= \mathbb{E}(DH) - \mu_D \mathbb{E}(H) - \mu_H \mathbb{E}(D) + \mu_D \mu_H \\
&= \mathbb{E}(DH) - \mu_D \mu_H \\
&= \mathbb{E}(DH) - \mathbb{E}(D)\mathbb{E}(H).
\end{aligned}$$

The means are constants, so the cross terms reduce to the product of the means. Here,

$$\text{Cov}(D, H) = .30 - (.40)(.60) = \boxed{.06}.$$

Positive covariance indicates that participation and employment tend to move together.

Solution 6: Correlation and recoding (continued)

3.

$$\text{Corr}(D, H) = \frac{.06}{\sqrt{.24}\sqrt{.24}} = \frac{.06}{.24} = \boxed{.25}.$$

Dividing by standard deviations removes units and gives a scale-invariant measure of linear association.

Recoding the variables

4. For $Q = 100D$ and $U = 1 - H$,

$$\text{Cov}(Q, H) = 100(.06) = 6, \qquad \text{Corr}(Q, H) = .25,$$
$$\text{Cov}(D, U) = -\text{Cov}(D, H) = -.06, \qquad \text{Corr}(D, U) = -.25.$$

Positive scaling preserves correlation; reversing the employment indicator reverses its sign.

These associations alone do not identify a causal effect of training.

Problem 7: Can zero correlation hide a relationship?

A student's deviation from target work hours is $X \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$, with each value equally likely. The scheduling penalty index is $Z = X^2$.

1. List the possible pairs (X, Z) and their joint probabilities.
2. Calculate $\mathbb{E}(X)$, $\mathbb{E}(Z)$, $\text{Var}(X)$, and $\text{Var}(Z)$.
3. Find $\mathbb{E}(XZ)$, $\text{Cov}(X, Z)$, and $\text{Corr}(X, Z)$.
4. Compare $\Pr(Z = 0 \mid X = 0)$ with $\Pr(Z = 0)$. Are X and Z independent?
5. Explain why your answers about correlation and independence are compatible.

Solution 7: Zero correlation can hide dependence

1.

X	$Z = X^2$	Probability
-1	1	$1/3$
0	0	$1/3$
1	1	$1/3$

2.

$$\mathbb{E}(X) = 0, \qquad \mathbb{E}(Z) = \frac{2}{3},$$

$$\mathrm{Var}(X) = \frac{2}{3}, \quad \mathrm{Var}(Z) = \frac{2}{3} - \left(\frac{2}{3}\right)^2 = \frac{2}{9}.$$

3.

$$\mathbb{E}(XZ) = \frac{-1 + 0 + 1}{3} = 0,$$

$$\mathrm{Cov}(X, Z) = 0 - 0\left(\frac{2}{3}\right) = 0,$$

$$\mathrm{Corr}(X, Z) = \frac{0}{\sqrt{2/3}\sqrt{2/9}} = 0.$$

Yet conditioning changes the distribution: **4.**

$$\Pr(Z = 0 \mid X = 0) = 1 \neq \frac{1}{3} = \Pr(Z = 0).$$

5.

Interpretation

X and Z are dependent: X determines Z exactly. Correlation measures linear association and can be zero for a nonlinear relationship.

Problem 8: How risky is a two-part support payment?

Use the observational (D, H) distribution from Problem 4. You found

$$\mathbb{E}(D) = .40, \quad \mathbb{E}(H) = .60, \quad \text{Var}(D) = \text{Var}(H) = .24, \quad \text{Cov}(D, H) = .06.$$

The university pays 100 euros for participating in training and 200 euros for being employed. Total support is $S = 100D + 200H$.

1. Compute $\mathbb{E}(S)$, $\text{Var}(S)$, and its standard deviation. Include the covariance term.
2. How much would the variance be understated if covariance were incorrectly set to zero?

Solution 8: The risk of a two-part support payment

1. For $S = 100D + 200H$, expected support is

$$\mathbb{E}(S) = 100(.40) + 200(.60) = 160 \text{ euros.}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{Var}(S) &= 100^2 \,\text{Var}(D) + 200^2 \,\text{Var}(H) + 2(100)(200)\,\text{Cov}(D, H) \\
&= 2{,}400 + 9{,}600 + 2{,}400 = 14{,}400 \text{ euros}^2, \\
\text{SD}(S) &= \sqrt{14{,}400} = 120 \text{ euros.}
\end{aligned}$$

2. Omitting covariance gives 12,000 euros^2, understating variance by 2,400 euros^2.

Problem 9: What can two employment responses tell us?

Employment indicators H_1 and H_2 are independent draws from a population with $\Pr(H_i = 1) = .60$. Define

$$\overline{H} = \frac{H_1 + H_2}{2}.$$

1. List the four ordered samples (H_1, H_2) and their probabilities.
2. Construct the exact sampling distribution of $\overline{H}$.
3. Calculate $\mathbb{E}(\overline{H})$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\overline{H})$ directly from that distribution.
4. Check your answers using $\mathbb{E}(\overline{H}) = \mu_H$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\overline{H}) = \sigma_H^2/n$.

Solution 9: The exact sampling distribution

1. Independence gives the probability of each ordered pair as a product:

(H_1, H_2)	Probability	$\overline{H}$
$(0,0)$	$.4 \times .4 = .16$	0
$(0,1)$	$.4 \times .6 = .24$	.5
$(1,0)$	$.6 \times .4 = .24$	.5
$(1,1)$	$.6 \times .6 = .36$	1

2. Collect equal values of the average:

h	$\Pr(\overline{H} = h)$
0	.16
.5	$.24 + .24 = .48$
1	.36

3.

$$\mathbb{E}(\overline{H}) = 0(.16) + .5(.48) + 1(.36) = .60,$$
$$\mathbb{E}(\overline{H}^2) = 0^2(.16) + .5^2(.48) + 1^2(.36) = .48,$$
$$\text{Var}(\overline{H}) = .48 - (.60)^2 = .12.$$

4. The i.i.d. formula confirms $\mathbb{E}(\overline{H}) = .60 = \mu_H$ and $\text{Var}(\overline{H}) = .12 = \sigma_H^2/2 = .60(.40)/2$.

Problem 10: How precise is a survey's average wage?

For this problem and Problem 11, model hourly wages $Y_1, \ldots, Y_n$ as i.i.d. draws with population mean $\mu_Y = 15$ euros and standard deviation $\sigma_Y = 6$ euros.

1. Derive $\mathbb{E}(\overline{Y})$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\overline{Y})$. Identify where independence is used.
2. Compute the variance and standard deviation of $\overline{Y}$ for $n = 25$ and $n = 100$.
3. Does quadrupling the sample size divide the standard deviation by four?
4. How large must n be for the standard deviation of $\overline{Y}$ to be at most .50 euros?
5. If students' wages are positively correlated, what missing terms would make the i.i.d. variance formula too small?

Solution 10: Sample size and earnings precision

1.

$$\mathbb{E}(\overline{Y}) = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}\mathbb{E}(Y_i) = 15, \qquad \mathrm{Var}(\overline{Y}) = \frac{1}{n^2}\left[\sum_{i=1}^{n}\mathrm{Var}(Y_i) + \sum_{i\neq j}\mathrm{Cov}(Y_i, Y_j)\right] = \frac{36n + 0}{n^2} = \frac{36}{n}.$$

Independence makes the cross-observation covariances zero. Therefore $\mathrm{SD}(\overline{Y}) = 6/\sqrt{n}$.

2.

Sample size	$\mathrm{Var}(\overline{Y})$ (euros squared)	$\mathrm{SD}(\overline{Y})$ (euros)
25	$36/25 = 1.44$	1.20
100	$36/100 = .36$	.60

- **3.** Quadrupling n **halves** the SD: $6/\sqrt{4n} = \frac{1}{2}(6/\sqrt{n})$.
- **4.** For SD at most .50: $6/\sqrt{n} \leq .50 \iff \sqrt{n} \geq 12 \iff n \geq 144$.
- **5.** Positive covariances add $n^{-2}\sum_{i\neq j}\mathrm{Cov}(Y_i, Y_j)$ to the variance. Omitting them understates uncertainty.

Problem 11: Is an unusually high survey mean surprising?

Hourly wages are i.i.d., with $\mu_Y = 15$ euros and $\sigma_Y = 6$ euros. The population distribution is right skewed with finite variance. A survey samples $n = 100$ students. Assume the CLT approximation is adequate at this sample size.

1. Use the central limit theorem to approximate the distribution of $\overline{Y}$. State whether the second normal parameter is a variance or a standard deviation.
2. Standardize and approximate $\Pr(\overline{Y} > 16.20)$.
3. Approximate $\Pr(13.80 \leq \overline{Y} \leq 16.20)$.
4. Would the normal approximation be exact for this population? What changes if the population itself is normal? Is the approximation automatically reliable at $n = 4$?

Use $\Phi(2) = .9772$ and $\Phi(-2) = .0228$, where Φ is the standard normal c.d.f.

Solution 11: A high average under the CLT

1. At $n = 100$, the assumed CLT approximation gives

$$\overline{Y} \overset{a}{\sim} \mathcal{N}\left(15, \frac{36}{100}\right) = \mathcal{N}(15, .36).$$

$$\text{SD}(\overline{Y}) = \sqrt{\text{Var}(\overline{Y})} = \sqrt{.36} = .60 \text{ euros.}$$

$$Z = \frac{\overline{Y} - 15}{.60} \overset{a}{\sim} \mathcal{N}(0, 1).$$

The second normal parameter is the variance; its square root is the standard deviation.

2.

$$\Pr(\overline{Y} > 16.20) \approx \Pr\left(Z > \frac{16.20 - 15}{.60}\right) = 1 - \Phi(2) = .0228.$$

3.

$$\Pr(13.80 \leq \overline{Y} \leq 16.20) \approx \Pr(-2 \leq Z \leq 2) = \Phi(2) - \Phi(-2) = .9544.$$

- **4.** For the right-skewed population these are approximate probabilities; if wages themselves are normal, the sample mean is *exactly* normal at every n. Finite variance does not guarantee an accurate approximation at $n = 4$; skewness and rare outliers affect finite-sample accuracy.

Problem 12: Which wage estimator should we use?

Let $Y_1, \ldots, Y_n$ be i.i.d. with unknown mean μ_Y and variance 36. Consider

$$A_n = \overline{Y}_n, \qquad B_n = Y_1, \qquad C_n = \overline{Y}_n + 1, \qquad T_n = \frac{n-1}{n}\overline{Y}_n.$$

1. For each rule, find its expectation, bias, and variance. Which are unbiased for all μ_Y?
2. Which rules are consistent for μ_Y? Explain what happens as $n \to \infty$.
3. At $n = 100$, which unbiased rule is more efficient? Does a smaller variance alone make a biased rule preferable?
4. For the observed wages $(9, 12, 15, 18, 21)$, compute the four estimates with $n = 5$. Distinguish each estimator from its realized estimate.

Solution 12: Bias and consistency of four rules

1. Let $a_n = (n-1)/n$. Linearity of expectation and $\text{Var}(cX) = c^2 \text{Var}(X)$ give:

Estimator	Expectation	Bias for μ_Y	Variance
$A_n = \overline{Y}_n$	μ_Y	0	$36/n$
$B_n = Y_1$	μ_Y	0	36
$C_n = \overline{Y}_n + 1$	$\mu_Y + 1$	1	$36/n$
$T_n = a_n \overline{Y}_n$	$a_n \mu_Y$	$-\mu_Y/n$	$a_n^2 \, 36/n$

Thus A_n **and** B_n **are unbiased for every** μ_Y. **2.**

- $A_n \xrightarrow{p} \mu_Y$ by the LLN: it is consistent.
- $B_n = Y_1$ retains the same nondegenerate distribution as n grows: it is inconsistent.
- $C_n \xrightarrow{p} \mu_Y + 1$: it is inconsistent for μ_Y.
- $a_n \to 1$ and $\overline{Y}_n \xrightarrow{p} \mu_Y$, so $T_n \xrightarrow{p} \mu_Y$: it is consistent, although generally biased at finite n.

Solution 12: Precision and realized estimates (continued)

3. At $n = 100$: compare the unbiased rules.

$$\text{Var}(A_{100}) = \frac{36}{100} = .36 \quad < \quad \text{Var}(B_{100}) = 36.$$

The sample mean is more efficient than the first observation among these unbiased rules. Shrinkage reduces variance but introduces bias:

$$\text{Var}(T_{100}) = .99^2(.36) = .352836, \qquad \mathbb{E}(T_{100}) - \mu_Y = -.01\mu_Y.$$

A smaller variance alone does not establish that a biased estimator is more accurate.

4. After observing $(9, 12, 15, 18, 21)$, use $n = 5$:

$$\bar{y} = \frac{9 + 12 + 15 + 18 + 21}{5} = 15,$$

rule	A_5	B_5	C_5	T_5
estimate	15	9	16	$\frac{4}{5}(15) = 12$

An *estimator* is the sample-based rule, random before observation; an *estimate* is the numerical value produced by the observed sample.

Problem 13: Why give every wage the same weight?

Four i.i.d. wages have mean μ_Y and variance 36. Normality is *not* assumed. Compare

$$M = \frac{Y_1 + Y_2 + Y_3 + Y_4}{4}, \qquad L = \frac{1}{2}Y_1 + \frac{1}{6}(Y_2 + Y_3 + Y_4).$$

1. Show that both estimators are linear and unbiased. Compare their variances.
2. For fixed weights, when is $\widehat{\mu} = \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i Y_i$ unbiased for every μ_Y? Derive its variance under i.i.d. sampling.
3. Under the unbiasedness restriction, use

$$\sum_{i=1}^{n} (w_i - 1/n)^2 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i^2 - 1/n \geq 0$$

   to find the minimum possible variance and the weights attaining it.
4. Explain each word in "Best Linear Unbiased Estimator" for the sample mean.

Solution 13: Comparing two wage averages

1. Both rules are fixed weighted sums, and both sets of weights sum to one:

$$\mathbb{E}(M) = \frac{1}{4}(4\mu_Y) = \mu_Y, \qquad \mathbb{E}(L) = \left(\frac{1}{2} + 3 \cdot \frac{1}{6}\right)\mu_Y = \mu_Y.$$

Independence removes covariance terms, so

$$\mathrm{Var}(M) = 36\left[4\left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^2\right] = 9,$$

$$\mathrm{Var}(L) = 36\left[\left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^2 + 3\left(\frac{1}{6}\right)^2\right] = 12.$$

Thus M is more efficient than L among these two unbiased estimators.

2. For any fixed weights $w_1, \ldots, w_n$ under the stated i.i.d. model,

$$\mathbb{E}\left(\sum_{i=1}^n w_i Y_i\right) = \mu_Y \sum_{i=1}^n w_i, \qquad \mathrm{Var}\left(\sum_{i=1}^n w_i Y_i\right) = 36\sum_{i=1}^n w_i^2.$$

Unbiasedness for *every* μ_Y requires $\sum_{i=1}^n w_i = 1$.

Solution 13: Why equal weights are BLUE (continued)

3. Impose the unbiasedness restriction $\sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i = 1$. Then

$$0 \le \sum_{i=1}^{n} \left(w_i - \frac{1}{n} \right)^2 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i^2 - \frac{2}{n} \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i + \frac{n}{n^2}$$
$$= \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i^2 - \frac{1}{n}.$$

Consequently,

$$\operatorname{Var}\left(\sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i Y_i \right) = 36 \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i^2 \ \ge \ \frac{36}{n},$$

with equality precisely when $w_i = 1/n$ for every i. The attaining estimator is $\overline{Y}$.

- **4. BLUE** means Best Linear Unbiased Estimator: best is smallest variance within the linear unbiased class, linear is a fixed weighted sum, and unbiased means the expectation equals the population mean.

Normality is unnecessary; i.i.d. sampling supplies the common mean, variance, and zero covariances used here.